Chapter 3 - The Beloved Princess

My mornings always began the same way: standing before my closet, choosing the color of my dress. I would gently place a plastic tiara upon my head in front of the mirror and use my fingers to tidy the curls my mother had set for me. To an outsider, it was just an ordinary detached house, but to four-year-old me, it was a magnificent castle.

As an only child born into the Sawaki family, I was utterly spoiled by my parents in my early years and raised like a princess. I took it for granted that all eyes were on me; I believed that being a princess was simply my role in life. There is, of course, a reason why I came to think this way.

It began before I was even born.

Apparently, my mother suffered from a condition that made it difficult to conceive, and doctors had told her that even if she did become pregnant, there was an eighty percent chance of miscarriage. Despite this, seven years after marrying my father, she conceived me, and she resolved to bring me into the world, even if it meant risking her own life.

Because it was determined that her body could not sustain a natural birth, I was born via C-section on October 24, 2002. My parents gave this miraculously born child the name "Ao." That is the girl who would later become known as Ado.

My parents wanted me to be a person with boundless possibility and freedom, like the clear blue sky or the endless ocean. They said they named me with that wish in mind. My mother told me that she chose not to use the kanji for "blue" (青) because she wanted anyone to be able to read my name without making a mistake.

Blue is the color of beginnings. The dawn sky and the silence before new greenery sprouts are both enveloped in blue. I loved this name, which represents the moment something begins to move.

Once I was old enough to understand, my mother told me:

"It truly feels as though you were a gift from God. Even the doctor at the hospital told us, 'Please give up on having any more children after this one. This baby is a miracle child, so please cherish and raise her with all your heart.'"

My father had been reading parenting books even before I was born; he spent endless time thinking about everything that would benefit his unborn child and put every single one of those thoughts into action.

Everything that touched my skin—from undergarments to diapers—was made of organic cotton. Even though he had no skill in cooking, he apparently made my baby food using organic ingredients. He also believed it was best to live somewhere surrounded by nature, so he chose a suburb far from the city center.

At that time, our home was a two-story house. It was by no means small—my father's billiard table sat prominently on the second floor. The layout consisted of the kitchen and living room on the first floor, and the bedrooms and study on the second. While I didn't have a room to call my own as a young child, my place during the day was the first-floor living room, which was always cluttered with my picture books and toys.

Normally, if a child repeatedly begged "Buy me this" or "Buy me that," they would be admonished with a "Not today." But my house was different. To my parents, I was the "miracle child" they had finally been blessed with. Anything I pointed to and said "I want it!" was bought for me.

As a result, the toys in the living room continued to snowball. If the current version of me were an adult living in the Sawaki neighborhood, I would probably say, "That's not a good way to raise a child"—it was a parade of indulgence.

My appearance was that of a princess through and through. I loved dresses with frilled ribbons and tulle, and my closet was filled with such clothes. Every morning, when I said "I want to wear that one," my mother would take it out and dress me in it. My hair, of course, was styled like a princess's. My mother would wind it in curlers while I slept, so when I woke up, my hair was in vertical rolls.

My mother, who had been a beauty consultant for a famous cosmetics brand, was proposed to by my father shortly after they met and married a few months later. After marriage, she began working at a large drugstore operated by my father's family. On the surface, my father also helped out with the family business, but in reality, he hardly worked at all. Since I was too young to remember much from that time, I only found out later from my mother that he spent most of his time at home taking care of me. My mother accepted the situation of earning the living expenses on her own, respecting my father's will to devote himself to childcare, believing that "everything is for Ao."

Therefore, at home, my father and I spent a long time alone together. We didn't go out to play often, but I remember occasionally visiting a nearby park to ride the swings or play with children my own age. Even so, I still loved being at home the most.

To me back then, the inside of our house was a perfect world that satisfied every desire as it bubbled up.

For my sake, Disney DVDs were always playing in the house. Moreover, they were all the English versions. This too was part of my parents' education plan. I heard that at the time, I

picked up English rapidly by listening to Mickey Mouse speak. Although I don't remember any of it now, apparently when I was three or four, I would climb into bed and chatter fluently to my mother: "This is a pillow," "I'm sleepy," "Good night, have sweet dreams."

During that period, I didn't listen to J-POP or children's songs at all. What I heard was mostly classical music, mixed with the rock music my father loved. My father particularly liked Queen and KISS, and he played them on LP records rather than CDs.

I bathed in the music my father chose like a shower of sound, but I have absolutely no memory of singing songs back then. I would hum Disney songs in English, but I never thought that singing was fun or that I wanted to be a singer.

Rather, I loved drawing. Using crayons, I drew nothing but my favorite Disney characters, though they were distorted. My mother still keeps those drawings; occasionally she takes them out and gazes nostalgically at the slightly warped Disney characters.

I also vividly remember my father patiently reading picture books to me. He searched for and bought a wide variety of books, from famous works to hidden gems, and read them aloud. The two I liked most were The Three Little Pigs and Watch Out, Mr. Cucumber.

My father's storytelling never grew boring. He would add inflection or change his voice to match the content and illustrations, entertaining whoever was listening. Looking back, this may have influenced my own expression after I became Ado.

And what I craved above all else was Disneyland. I was taken to that land of dreams more times than I can count. I still clearly remember everything: the music of the parades, the sweet smell of popcorn, and even the chilly night air just before the park closed.

The first time I went to Disneyland was when I was ten months old, so early I have no memory of it. After that, my parents took me almost every week with an annual passport. It is no exaggeration to say that I received a Disney elite education, immersed in Disney even before I could walk. To my young self, Disneyland was "another world" where my soul was set free.

There are countless anecdotes of Ao's selfishness from this era. My favorite phrase was, "I'm not going home until I ride Winnie the Pooh." One evening, while I had fallen asleep, my parents decided, "Let's go home for today," and stepped outside the gates. The moment they did, I apparently snapped awake and screamed and cried, "I haven't ridden it yet!" They were forced to re-enter the park and take me on the Pooh attraction; by the time I was satisfied and ready to leave, my parents were completely exhausted.

It wasn't just Pooh. "I'm not going home until I eat caramel popcorn" was another standard tantrum. On days I forgot to eat it, I would make a huge scene in the car on the way back. More than once or twice, my father would give in, turn the car around, re-enter the park to buy popcorn, and only then would I stop crying.

Whenever I remember these things, I feel ashamed of how selfish I was, and I sincerely feel that children really do need discipline.

My kindergarten was located very close to our house.

For me, who had left my beloved home to enter the outside world, kindergarten was the place where I experienced the first setback of my life. If I dig through my distant memories, the trigger for feeling that life was difficult and beginning to dislike myself may have been during this time.

Aside from playing at Disneyland, I was basically an indoor child, but I was energetic, mischievous, and a child who did whatever she wanted. Because I sought freedom so intensely, there were many instances where I did not act like everyone else.

First of all, I refused to wear the uniform. Saying "I won't go unless it's a princess dress," I attended kindergarten in a dress. Even at sports day, I didn't wear athletic clothes and showed up in a dress. Naturally, I was bombarded by comments from those around me: "Why is Ao-chan always in her own clothes?" or "It's weird to wear a dress to sports day."

Was it really that strange? When I asked my father and mother, the two of them didn't seem to mind and just laughed.

Furthermore, as a young child, my growth rate and the pace at which I acquired skills were incredibly slow. According to my mother, I didn't start walking until I was two, and I wasn't potty trained until around age four—very late. Because of this, there were times I went to kindergarten wearing diapers. I didn't think it was particularly shameful, but for the first time, I felt depressed when the other children told me, "Ao-chan, you still can't use the toilet, can you?" Everyone else could do it, but I was the only one who couldn't.

As an only child, I had almost no experience being compared to anyone until then, and I simply could not get used to the gaze of "comparing person A to person B" that was exchanged as a matter of course at the preschool.

The version of myself that couldn't do what everyone else did, and the gazes that found it amusing. As these experiences piled up, the number of days I didn't want to go to kindergarten increased. And the final blow came during an incident that happened during drawing time.

I loved drawing with crayons, but at that time, I only drew "swirls." However, because I used various colors and mixed large and small shapes, they were forms that had a definite meaning within myself. That day, too, I was drawing swirls during drawing time. Then, the child next to me peered over to look.

"Ao-chan, what are you drawing?"

"Fireworks!"

"Eh? Fireworks aren't like that. This is just a scribble. A spiral, right? Fireworks are drawn like this."

That child showed me a picture of typical fireworks, spreading out in radial lines.

"Look. See, fireworks are drawn like this. Right? It's different from yours, Ao-chan."

But to me, fireworks were spirals.

"It's okay! My fireworks are spirals of beautiful colors, like blue and yellow!"

The moment I declared this, my teacher approached from behind and said:

"No, 'spirals' aren't fireworks. Ao-chan, you are mistaken."

Looking back now, that teacher was the kind of person who would say "You're wearing plain clothes again," whenever I came to preschool with me in non-uniform attire, or "You're already four years old; it's strange that you're still in diapers." She was perhaps trying to guide me to be more like other people. Usually, she was kind, and both the other children and I loved her. That is exactly why a single sentence from her—"spirals aren't fireworks"—shattered my heart into pieces.

On my way home that day, I cried as I complained to my mother.

"The teacher said 'spirals aren't fireworks.' But I worked so hard to draw them beautifully."

Then, my mother answered in a voice devoid of hesitation.

"You can stop going to preschool now."

With those words, I was finally liberated from the fear of being compared to others and denied.

In the end, the preschool I entered at age four ended up being a place I left before a year had passed.

From my perspective, I was happy to spend all day in my favorite place—home. However, from a parent's point of view, staying shut inside the same place forever would limit the information and experiences one could encounter. I believe they wanted to take me outside as much as possible, or at least expose me to various works of art even within the house. That is why they took me to Disneyland every week, read me picture books, and let me listen to records.

Although I didn't go to preschool, it may have been a time where I accumulated various experiences instead. I never felt lonely because I lacked friends; instead, I learned the joy of playing alone and became absorbed in single things.

I often spent time with my mother at the toy section of shopping malls. In the trial areas, you could try out toys freely. I looked forward to touching new toys more than anything else, but at the same time, I also learned what "waiting your turn" meant.

There is a queue for the toys you want. While someone else is using them, you have no choice but to wait until that child is satisfied and leaves. Even when my mother said, "I'll buy it for you," I didn't nod in agreement immediately.

Until around age three, I had mostly been bought whatever I wanted, but by the time I was nearly five, I began to scrutinize whether something was truly a thing I "wanted." Therefore, when a toy wasn't available, I would wait patiently for the child before me to finish playing. I believed that there was meaning in the act of waiting itself.

Within me—a person who cannot endure even a second of something unpleasant—there was also a persistent side of me that would not give up on things I wanted. When I occasionally remember my younger self waiting quietly for her turn, I feel it connects to the mental fortitude I possess now as I continue to run forward as an Utaite.

I wait and wait, and finally, I pick up the toy and play with it for a few minutes before gently handing it over to the next child. Then, I leave the shopping mall. Clumsily, in that way, my younger self gradually experienced her first interactions with society.

Finally, the year came for me to enter elementary school. For the entrance ceremony, naturally, I could think of nothing other than a "princess dress." Normally, people would choose a slightly more mature suit or a dress, or perhaps a jacket with a collar (my mother did try to nudge me in that direction), but I insisted on "wearing a dress."

I requested patent leather shoes and a ruffled dress—and everything had to be unified in pink. To anyone else, it was such a flamboyant outfit that they might have wondered, "Where on earth did she buy clothes like this?" I attended the entrance ceremony with my hair in vertical curls and wearing a headline headband.

From the next day onward, I wasn't wearing frilly dresses anymore, but I didn't miss a single day of wearing a knee-length dress, curled hair, and a headband. Doing so led to me being approached by several older students a few days later.

"You're the girl who was a princess at the entrance ceremony, right?"

"It's the girl with the vertical curls. She was cute."

The feeling of attracting attention without realizing it was a mix of happiness and embarrassment. Still, somewhere in my heart, a small sense of pride welled up.

Around the time I entered elementary school, my family moved. This was so that my mother could open her own beauty salon.

It might sound strange coming from a daughter who is now completely spoiled by her, but my mother has always been meticulous about her appearance and possesses extensive knowledge of makeup. Her sense of style regarding hair and clothing was excellent. Although she was slightly older than the parents of my classmates, she looked so young that people were surprised when they told her age. She was a mother I could be proud of. That mother began to work fiercely, owning her own shop.

Our new home was in a four-story building in Zōshigaya.

It wasn't right next to the station, but there was a shopping street nearby, and it wasn't too far from the station either. Behind the building, there was a large temple with a massive ginkgo tree that was several hundred years old. In my memory, I have never seen a ginkgo tree larger than that one. When autumn came, the leaves turned yellow and were beautiful.

My mother's shop was on the first floor of the building, and our family lived on the fourth floor. Come to think of it, not having an elevator in that building was tough. Now that I am an adult and living alone in an apartment, every time I take an elevator, I remember those days and think, "Ugh—I had to use the stairs up to the fourth floor back then!"

My mother's shop started as a beauty salon, but gradually it began selling stationery as well, and soon it became like a general store. It was a strange space where neighborhood mothers buying cosmetics mixed with elementary and middle school students buying stationery.

At that time, my father had left the family drugstore and taken a night-shift job. His schedule was irregular, and since he worked mostly during the late-night hours, he spent very little time at home, and there were days when we wouldn't see each other for several days.

Whenever I returned from school, I never went straight up to our home on the fourth floor; instead, I would say "I'm home!" and head first to the shop on the first floor. I would place my backpack in a corner of the salon and spread my homework out on a small table next to the counter. While glancing at the interactions between my mother and her customers, I would slowly move my pencil.

Even after entering elementary school, home remained the center of my world. My princess mindset remained unchanged, and even when playing with classmates in the schoolyard during recess, I felt that "something was different." Therefore, I loved the time at home where I could do everything freely.

There were rules everywhere at school. There was a timetable, and it was decided that "now is the time to do this." Group activities, lining up in rows, and taking one's seat when the chime rang—these were all part of a world where collective living was the norm.

Normally, preschool is where one "practices" these things, but since I quit halfway through, I didn't know most of them. Therefore, the children around me who followed the rules properly seemed much more like adults than I did.

And above all, the most shocking thing was the fact that "none of the others wanted to be princesses." I was simply amazed and puzzled as to why no one else sought after the princess look that I believed to be the absolute peak of loveliness.

Then, finally, I realized clearly: I am different from the other children.

"Is it embarrassing to be the only one who is different?"
"Was what I thought was good actually a mistake?"
"Is what everyone else does always the correct thing?"
Such questions never left my mind.

Still, as I continued in collective living, my thoughts were gradually dyed by the rules that existed there. And slowly, I begin to think that "the majority = the correct answer."

By the time I became a second-grader, my appearance and behavior approached those of an "ordinary elementary school student." My attire was no longer that of a princess; I began wearing only light blue clothes and denim pants. There was a clear reason for this.

One day, while walking home in my princess attire as usual, I was suddenly surrounded by several older students coming out of a nearby ballet school.

「Why are you wearing clothes like this?"

"This isn't something you wear to school!"

"How do you get your curly hair to look like that?"

Bombarded by these questions in rapid succession, I collapsed right where I stood. The older students weren't necessarily bullying me; they were likely just directing their raw curiosity toward me. However, the memory of the fear and vigilance I felt in that moment led me to make a firm decision: I would never let myself be put in that position again.

To protect my heart, I went home and made a request to my mother: light blue or blue pants and shirts, sweatshirts, and white sneakers. It was clothing that was the exact opposite of the

"princess image" I held within me. I began wearing the clothes and shoes she bought for me immediately the next day, and I went to school with my hair straight instead of curled, and without any hair accessories. In this way, like a princess whose magic had worn off or who had been cursed, I completely transformed myself.

Having become "just an ordinary elementary school student" in the eyes of others, I was able to make a few friends. However, since I was a "home-body" type—a common trait among only children—I always felt like I was just following someone else's lead.

Gradually, perhaps noticing that there were many things I struggled with and that I was a "child who couldn't do things," one of my friends began to teach me various things.

For example, I am slow at running. In elementary school, the world is one where "being fast is justice," so I was self-conscious about my lack of speed. When that happened, this friend carefully taught me how to position my feet and how to swing my arms.

For instance, I am bad at arithmetic. Then, that friend—who was also good at studying—would peer into my notebook and explain the calculation steps in a way that was easy to understand.

"Ao-chan, do you get it? If you don't, feel free to ask me as many times as you need."

"Yeah, thanks."

Even as I gave those thanks, something else was playing on my mind.

This girl is good at sports, smart, and has lots of friends. I love her, but does she actually like me? She probably doesn't like me that much in the way I do. But then, why is she teaching me? Maybe it's because I'm slow to learn things, and she feels sorry for me, so she's helping me.

That voice had been echoing inside me constantly. Of course, we got along well normally, but I lacked confidence. The anxiety of wondering if there was truly someone who could love a person like me—someone different, someone strange—made me even more suspicious. I never put those feelings into words. I ruminated on the emotions held in my chest alone, always observing the existence of "Ao Sawaki" from somewhere far away.

I had been unable to fit in with those around me for some reason, but I wasn't always lonely. Yet, that didn't mean every day was enjoyable.

Then one day, I encountered a light that would change my life forever. It was so dazzling that it felt like an impact, forcing me to instinctively close my eyes. Before I knew it, I was chasing after it with obsession, and at the end of that path, I found a place where I belonged.

That was Vocaloid.

The first time I heard the word "Vocaloid" itself was in the first grade of elementary school. I remember finding the term while trying to search for things on my father's laptop by mimicking what I had seen others do.

However, at that time, it was just a feeling of "I guess such a thing exists." It wasn't until a few months later that I clearly recognized the existence of Vocaloid. That happened when I went to visit my cousin Chihiro-chan's house. My father's sister's daughter, Chihiro-chan, was the same age as me and we got along well because our interests were similar. One day, while showing me the screen of her desktop computer, Chihiro-chan said to me:

"Ao-chan, do you know about this? I've been really into this lately."

What Chihiro-chan showed me was a video called *The Daughter of Evil*. There, for the first time, I experienced the singing voice of a Vocaloid.

Once upon a time, in a certain place,
At the pinnacle of a kingdom
Of absolute cruelty and vice,
Reigned a princess of fourteen years.

Splendid and luxurious furnishings,
A servant whose face looked just like hers,
Her favorite horse's name was Josephine,
Everything, absolutely everything, belonged to her.

Whoa—what is this!!

Who drew this illustration?

And this cute voice, "Kagamine Rin"—who on earth is she???

Shocked, I begged Chihiro-chan to play the video over and over again. I learned that Kagamine Rin was not a real singer, but a digital voice called a Vocaloid. When I returned home, I searched for "Vocaloid" on my father's computer and began exploring the secrets of the songs and videos Chihiro-chan had introduced me to.

I understood now. Vocaloid is a technology where if you input the melody and lyrics into a computer, a character sings in a singing voice based on sampled human voices. The song I had just heard was sung by a Vocaloid named "Kagamine Rin," and I discovered there were various other characters, such as "Hatsune Miku" and "Megurine Luka."

As I researched further, I discovered that the *The Daughter of Evil* video I saw at Chihiro-chan's house was not the original (the source video), but a video where someone had

overlaid a "heartwarming" animation they had drew over the original song. In the world of Vocaloid, it seems one song can spawn various derivative works.

As I watched videos one after another, I eventually reached the original *The Daughter of Evil* video. The song was created by mothy. The image model was Marie Antoinette, the Queen of France. A noble princess who, in the end, was captured during the French Revolution and stood upon the guillotine—a tragic "princess." Overlapping my own experience with that of *The Daughter of Evil*, I immersed myself in the world of Vocaloid.

Whenever I returned from school, I would take over my father's computer and watch Vocaloid videos incessantly. Having listened to them so many times that I memorized the melodies of countless songs, I would listen, then sing, then sing, then search, and encounter even more Vocaloid songs. Repeating this cycle, I gradually learned about the background of the world of Vocaloid culture.

The starting point of this culture was the video-sharing site "Niconico Dōga." It was a unique cultural sphere where comments flowed across the screen from right to left, with tags and rankings, and where remixes and covers were born in rapid succession.

In the world of Vocaloid, there are "Vocaloid-Ps" who create songs using Vocaloids, and there are also people called "Utaite" and "Eshi." Niconico Dōga was like a laboratory where ideas could be cross-pollinated, and a gathering place for countless talents.

My opportunities to encounter J-POP or idol music were limited to the school broadcasts during lunch break or the television playing in the background while we ate at home. Therefore, it took almost no time at all for the Vocaloid songs I listened to every day on my computer to become my "entire" world of music.

I want to know more about this world; I want to become a resident of this world.

The entrance to that world was a piece of software called *Flipnote Studio* for the DSi, which I got in the second grade.

At the time, I was obsessed with games like *Nintendogs*, *Rhythm Heaven*, and *Tamagotchi*. In between playing those, I found a free drawing software. That was *Flipnote Studio*, commonly known as "UgoMemo."

As the name suggests, it was software that could be used as a notepad, but if you played back several drawings you had made, you could create videos like a flip-book animation. Furthermore, since you could record audio, combining illustrations with sound allowed you to make something like a simple animation. Since there was a place to upload these animations online, I spent hours on end watching the works being posted.

There were so many wonderful illustrations and animations uploaded to UgoMemo, and they were just so cool.

"Amazing! So cool!" I would shout, frolicking around the house by myself.

Maybe I should try drawing something and posting it to UgoMemo. "Niconico Dōga" was still a very distant world, but if it was on the DS I used every day for gaming, maybe I could do it too.

That's what I thought, and I took action in the spring of my third grade. Using the small, thin stylus, I drew an illustration of a girl...

I connected to the internet and posted it.

Next, I decided to try posting a song using the recording function of UgoMemo. The song I chose was "Senbonzakura."

I drew an illustration of Hatsune Miku as cutely as I possibly could, and recorded my voice using the built-in microphone of my Nintendo DS. It was just a single phrase from the chorus recorded a cappella, but I was so excited that I practically jumped for joy. After all, when you think of Vocaloid, you think of "Senbonzakura." I figured that if it was such a high-profile song, quite a few people might actually listen to my "Utattemita" video. The thought left me feeling as though my heart were being squeezed by a wave of shyness.

Would anyone even listen to my singing? No, it's just a clumsy, a cappella recording—nobody will listen to that... But still, I've drawn my favorite illustrations and sung my favorite Vocaloid song, and I've posted it in a place where anyone can see and hear it. Just doing that is amazing in itself...

Looking back, I believe the whirlpool of emotion I felt then was the first sprout of my creative drive. Around this time, posting illustrations to UgoMemo became the catalyst for me to immerse myself in drawing.

At the time, I was captivated by a manga called "Uchi no San-shimai." It was a work by Purittsu Matsumoto that depicted the daily lives of three sisters—Hu-chan, Su-chan, and Chi-chan—from the mother's perspective, and it had even been adapted into anime and games. It was popular on UgoMemo as well, and a massive amount of fan-made derivative works were being posted.

Among them were people creating animations using "Uchi no San-shimai" characters with Vocaloid songs as background music. I stared at them, my eyes sparkling with excitement, thinking, "So cute!" Perhaps I could draw them too. When I actually tried putting pen to paper, it turned out surprisingly well. Overjoyed, I began drawing them one after one in a frenzy.

There were truly so many geniuses on UgoMemo.

My favorite Hu-chan, Su-chan, and Chi-chan would spin and dance to Vocaloid songs on the tiny screen, or carry out conversations with the music as their backdrop. Through those works, I discovered new songs.

"There's a song like this? That's so cool."
"Somehow, it just stays in my head."

Using credits and comments as clues, I searched for the original songs and played them. Before I knew it, the number of Vocaloid songs I knew had grown exponentially.

As I drew "Uchi no San-shimai," I suddenly found to myself thinking, "It would be wonderful if I could become a manga artist." It might have been simply that the joy of drawing the three sisters connected with the word "manga artist" in my mind, but it was an indescribable feeling of happiness.

Yet, it felt a bit strange. Usually, a feeling of denial would come first—I'd tell myself, "It's impossible anyway," and immediately extinguish any desire to achieve something. But for some reason, that didn't happen this time.

As I immersed myself in the things I loved, the desire to "try it" pushed aside the voice of negation. Before I realized it, the will to reach for what I wanted had grown surprisingly strong within me.

UgoMemo worked such that you could post to an official gallery if you connected to the internet, and people could leave comments or mark works as favorites by giving them "stars." Yellow stars could be given by anyone in any number, but truly amazing works were awarded Green Stars or Red Stars, which were limited in quantity. I began to desperately want those stars.

Around that time, I focused my efforts on creating original short animations. The protagonist was a girl with long black hair and blue eyes—much like the current Ado. It was a simple story where she would walk through town, smile, or talk to other original characters; however, I continued to draw and post them with all my might.

Then one day, there was a wonderful surprise.

Wait, my work has a star! And it's... Green!!!

I instinctively sent a comment: "Thank you so much, I'm really happy!"

The reply came immediately: "Your art isとても上手ですね、すごくかわいいです" (Your drawing is very good, and it's very cute).

Because of UgoMemo, I was able to pursue my own form of expression. It taught me the joy of expressing the "likes" within myself and connecting with people in the digital world.

At that time, the internet and general society were still quite separate. If I mentioned "Vocaloid" to my classmates, they would just tilt their heads in confusion. Let alone words like "Hatsune Miku" or "Senbonzakura," which no one knew.

Even so, in 2011—the year I first sang "Senbonzakura" on UgoMemo—I felt Vocaloid beginning to slowly gain recognition outside the world of Niconico Dōga, as Hatsune Miku was featured in commercials for Toyota USA and Google.

I believe that was an era where perceptions of Vocaloid shifted gradually along with Hatsune Miku's popularity. The image of the "gloomy otaku" began to fade, and there were more instances where it was discussed as digital art or a new form of musical expression. Consequently, Vocaloid-Ps began to attract sudden attention.

"Vocaloid-P" is a term born from Niconico Dōga, referring to creators who produce songs using software like Vocaloid and post them. The "P" stands for Producer. Creators were given nicknames ending in "P," such as "XX-P." In the beginning, there was a culture where viewers would come with up their their own names for the producers, and eventually, more creators began to identify themselves as "XX-P." I memorized these unique and melodic names alongside the songs they created.

By the time I was in fourth grade, I knew almost all the famous Vocaloid-Ps and their representative songs. Every time I opened my computer, I checked for new releases from my favorite producers. As soon as a new work was uploaded, I played it on repeat. My days—no, my very life—were being colored by Vocaloid. The main reason I fell so deeply in love with it was simple: it was just overwhelmingly cool. I was captivated and thrilled by the sensibilities of the Vocaloid-Ps and the worlds they depicted.

I watched the videos, pondered the meaning of the lyrics, and closed my eyes to listen closely to the singing voice once more. Then, I tried singing them myself. The more I sang, the more the brilliance of the songs pressed upon my heart, to the point where I would instinctively cover my face with my hands.

When I would sing Vocaloid songs alone in front of the computer, my father, hearing my voice, would praise me without reservation: "Ao is so good at singing; you're a genius!"

"Daddy, it's because this song is wonderful!"

Every time I praised the music in words, the Vocaloid songs became even more than special to me.

And if I am to speak of this era, I cannot leave out the episode of the "secret base." The reason why the current Ado continues to stick to her style of recording alone is exactly found right there.

At that time, I created my own space in the bedroom closet, and spent a lot of time there.

I lived in a house on the fourth floor of a small building, and I didn't have my own room. While my friends had their own rooms, I was envious and tried begging for one, but my mother would tell me, "It's impossible, because there are no rooms available."

Still unable to give up, I modified the closet to create my own secret base.

I brought in a desk lamp, read books and manga, played games on my DS, and hummed Vocaloid songs. Since it was a closet, I couldn't put much in there, but I put in a comfortable cushion and a small table so that I could draw, and decorated the walls with my own drawings. Even when my mother told me, "You'll ruin your eyes," I didn't care, and spent my days like that. As a result, my eyesight plummeted, and I started wearing glasses, but I I have no regrets.

When I was in my secret base, I was free. I could forget the suffocating feeling and the restlessness in an instant.

While immersing myself in my hobbies, schoolwork was a complete disaster.

I wasn't good at studying from the start, and I often had to stay after school for remedial lessons. I struggled not only with math but also with Japanese language arts. For those common test questions like "Choose the author's feelings from the following options," I would be completely lost, wondering, "How on earth am I supposed to know how someone else feels?"

There were still friends who would help me and teach me things, and while I grateful for their help, I felt discouraged at the same time. It's amazing that people my own age can teach me. I can't teach anyone. Everyone else can do it, but I can't. Those feelings raced through my head, and before I knew it, I would find myself looking down on myself.

Even so, after I fell in love with Vocaloid and became more than a little knowledgeable, and began to be able to give shape to my small works on UgoMemo, a joy—no, a "sense of happiness" that surpassed even that—was born.

Because I couldn't do the "normal things" like studying or sports well, the time I spent immersed in the world of Vocaloid was unbearably enjoyable. While I was staying after school for remedial lessons, writing the same kanji over and over again in the grid paper, all I thought about was: "When I get home, Vocaloid is waiting for me." That was alone.

I lived as someone who felt she was a failure, while simultaneously wishing to become a cool middle school or high school student. I had to face two versions of myself—two figures that were as different as heaven and earth. To fill that gap, I wondered what I should start with, on

the way home, in the bath, and even in my bed. I felt that if I ran away from thinking about it, I't would truly become a useless person. Gradually, it became a habit to try and think through things without running away.

thought
One day, I had a fateful encounter.

As it turned out, there was one student in the neighboring class who knew more about Vocaloids than I did, and we started hanging out occasionally after school. It happened one day while I was visiting their house. They turned the living room computer toward me and pressed the play button on a video.

"Ao-chan, isn't this voice cool?"

"This is a cover of a Vocaloid song, right? The voice is so high. Is it a woman?"

"No, it's a man."

"A man? That's amazing. Does he appear on TV?"

"He doesn't. Only on the internet."

"What? You can only hear them on the internet...?"

"Yeah. But if they become really famous, they sometimes perform as an Utaite at a Niconico Dōga event called 'Niconico Cho Party.'"

"I see... so this is what an 'Utaite' is..."

I had vaguely known about the existence of "Utaite," but this was the first time I had actually peered into that world. After that, my friend explained in great detail how many cool Utaite existed in this scene. They also told me that the singer in the first video I watched was Mafumafu.

A sound like a bell ringing echoed through my head.

Why hadn't I noticed the existence of Utaite until now?

Utaite are incredible. How is it possible that someone can be a man and produce such beautiful high notes, be so skilled, yet only be found on the internet? You can't even imagine their age or gender just by listening to their singing voice. That, too, was wonderful.

I had been following the works of Vocaloid-Ps every day, feeling as though I was "someone who knew their stuff," yet for some reason, I had overlooked the existence of Utaite. Once that door was opened thanks to my friend, a desire to become an Utaite erupted from the depths of my heart with immense force—like a rocket flying in a straight line toward the sky.

The concept of the "Utaite" dramatically changed my image of what it meant to be a singer. To me, a singer was someone who stood in the spotlight, dancing with a smile and performing on television programs. While I loved singing, I didn't think I was cute, I couldn't dance, and I was gloomy and shy; I believed that standing on a stage to sing was impossible for me.

But an Utaite could become popular without revealing their true identity. They could cover the Vocaloid songs they loved and shine brilliantly. Moreover, they could choose their own handle and design their own visual persona to use for their activities. This was it. This was exactly what I wanted to do.

I tried it.

The small light that had been lit in my heart—the desire to become an Utaite—became the guiding light for the path I would later walk as Ado.